



SESSION 4 — MENTOR GUIDE

My Inner Voice

This is a vulnerable session. Many athletes are ashamed of negative self-talk. Actively normalize it.

SESSION GOAL

Help the athlete become aware of their self-talk patterns and develop a more constructive inner voice.

CONVERSATION FLOW

OPENING (5 MIN)

""How do you talk to yourself when you make a mistake? Can you tell me honestly?""

💡 Go first yourself: "I know I used to be very hard on myself too..." That opens the door.

EXPLORING (15 MIN)

""Has that inner voice always been there — or did someone teach it to you at some point?""

💡 Self-talk has an origin. Discovering it can be liberating.

DEEPENING (10 MIN)

""What would change in your performance if that voice became kinder?""

💡 Research shows: self-compassion increases performance. Share this if it fits.

CLOSING (5 MIN)

""Let's formulate an anchor sentence together. Let the athlete choose it.""

💡 The sentence must be theirs — not your suggestion. Ask: "Which sentence sounds like yours?"

OBSERVE

- How quickly does the athlete acknowledge negative self-talk — or do they deny it?
- Is there a pattern? (After mistakes? Under pressure? With certain players?)
- What is the emotion when they describe that inner voice — shame, humor, pain?
- Note: extreme self-criticism can be a signal of something deeper. Flag it.

△ NOTE

If self-criticism is extreme ("I'm useless", "I don't deserve my spot") — normalize, but flag this internally as a point of attention. Refer if needed.

CLOSING

Repeat their anchor sentence back: "The sentence you choose is..." Make it concrete: "When are you going to use that this week?" That increases the chance of transfer.

MENTOR NOTES